

SOME PEOPLE SEE GHOSTS.
SOME PEOPLE SEE THEMSELVES.

THE GHOST THEY CALLED ME

A COLLECTION OF TWELVE SHORT STORIES

AM I
THE PROBLEM?

Sky 하늘

THE GHOST THEY CALLED ME

Some people see ghosts.

Some people see themselves.

Sky하늘

THE GHOST THEY CALLED ME

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A GENTLE NOTE

This collection explores stories involving mental health, grief, trauma, loneliness, supernatural beliefs, and the ways people sometimes misunderstand suffering.

Some stories are frightening. Others may feel uncomfortable because the things they explore are not entirely imaginary.

The purpose of these stories is not to diagnose, mock, or dismiss anyone experiencing mental-health difficulties.

Sometimes what looks supernatural may have a psychological explanation.

Sometimes people use mental illness as an excuse for the things they do.

And sometimes, we simply don't know the truth.

Not every ghost is a ghost.

Not every illness is visible.

And not every story has an answer.

***FOR THOSE WHO WERE NEVER
BELIEVED.***

And for those who were afraid to speak.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

These are twelve stories.

Twelve people.

Twelve different ways of seeing what we cannot explain.

Some stories may have an answer.

Some may not.

You may find yourself wondering whether what happened was supernatural, psychological, or simply human.

Don't rush to decide.

Sometimes the uncertainty is part of the story.

Read slowly.

Look twice.

And when you reach the end, ask yourself:

Was it really a ghost?

Or was there something else we failed to see?

CONTENTS

01 THE WOMAN AT THE WINDOW	2
02 THE HOUSE THAT PRAYED	22
03 THE MAN WHO WASN'T SICK	40
04 THE ROOM AT THE END OF THE HALL	58
05 THE MAN IN ROOM 17	76
06 THE NAME THEY GAVE HER	97
07 THE BOY EVERYONE BELIEVED	115
08 THE VOICE FROM THE EMPTY ROOM	131
09 THE HEALER'S LAST PATIENT	147
10 THE GIRL WHO NEVER SLEPT	164
11 THE DIAGNOSIS.....	181
12 THE LAST DOOR.....	203

AFTER THE LAST STORY

222

01

THE WOMAN AT THE WINDOW

Some people see ghosts.

Some people see themselves.

He first saw the woman on a Tuesday night.

Rain had been falling since evening, turning the narrow road outside his house into a dark ribbon beneath the streetlights. Water slid slowly down the bedroom window, breaking the orange light outside into long, trembling lines.

The room was warm.

Too warm.

He had turned the ceiling fan to its highest setting, but the air barely moved. The fan rotated above him with a soft mechanical hum, interrupted every few seconds by a faint clicking sound.

He had been awake for nearly an hour.

Sleep had become difficult lately.

Some nights, he would lie in bed until morning, staring at the ceiling while his mind replayed conversations he wished he had never had. Other nights, he would wake suddenly with no idea why, his heart already racing before he was fully conscious.

That night, however, there was only the rain.

Until he saw her.

At first, he thought she was waiting for someone.

A woman stood beneath the tree across the road.

She was completely still.

He frowned and sat up.

The rain was heavy enough that he could barely make out the houses opposite his own, but somehow he could see her clearly.

Long dark hair.

White clothing.

Bare feet.

Her face was turned toward his house.

Toward his window.

He reached for his glasses.

The woman didn't move.

He leaned closer to the glass.

A flash of lightning briefly illuminated the street.

For a fraction of a second, he saw her face.

She was looking directly at him.

He pulled the curtains shut.

His heart was beating too quickly.

He remained sitting on the edge of his bed, listening to the rain hammering against the roof.

"Imagining things."

He said it quietly.

He wasn't sure whether he was trying to convince himself or the empty room.

He went downstairs.

His mother was sitting alone in the living room. The television was on, but the volume was low enough that the sound of rain outside seemed louder.

She looked over when he entered.

"Why are you awake?"

"Can't sleep."

She studied his face for a moment.

"You've been saying that a lot lately."

He shrugged.

"Work."

She didn't ask anything else.

Instead, she pointed toward the kitchen.

"Go drink some water."

He smiled faintly.

"Okay."

That was how most conversations ended in their house.

Okay.

Eat.

Sleep.

Work.

Tomorrow.

Nobody said *Are you alright?*

And nobody answered *No*.

•

The next morning, he forgot about the woman.

Or at least, he tried to.

By eight o'clock, the previous night's rain had left the air heavy and humid. The road outside was still wet, and the smell of damp earth lingered around the house.

He went to work.

He answered messages.

He attended meetings.

He laughed when someone made a joke.

He complained about traffic.

By lunchtime, the woman seemed ridiculous.

There was no woman.

There was only a tired man who hadn't been sleeping properly.

When he returned home that evening, his mother was sitting at the dining table.

She didn't look up immediately.

"Your aunt called."

He put his bag down.

"Why?"

"She heard something from your cousin."

He pulled out a chair.

"Heard what?"

His mother finally looked at him.

"That you've been seeing things."

His hand stopped halfway toward the chair.

"What?"

"Your cousin said you told him you saw someone outside the house."

"I didn't tell him that."

"He said you did."

"I just—"

He stopped.

His mother watched him carefully.

"You saw someone?"

He looked toward the window.

"No."

The answer came too quickly.

His mother sighed.

"I think you should see someone."

"A doctor?"

She hesitated.

"No."

He already knew what she meant.

"A healer?"

She nodded.

He leaned back in his chair.

"Mak, I'm tired. That's all."

"I didn't say you were possessed."

"You didn't have to."

Silence settled over the table.

The ceiling fan above them turned slowly.

His mother lowered her voice.

"Sometimes things happen that we don't understand."

He looked down.

He wanted to tell her there was nothing to understand.

He wanted to tell her he was fine.

Instead, he said:

"Okay."

•

Three nights later, he woke at 3:17 a.m.

He didn't know why.

There was no rain.

No thunder.

No sound from the television downstairs.

The house was completely silent.

For several seconds, he lay still beneath the thin blanket,
listening to his own breathing.

Then he noticed something.

The curtains were moving.

Just slightly.

A narrow strip of darkness appeared between them.

He sat up.

The bedroom was colder than it had been when he went to
sleep.

He stared at the curtains.

Something was standing behind them.

A shadow.

A human shape.

He reached for his phone.

3:17 a.m.

His fingers felt cold.

He called his mother.

She answered after several rings.

"Hello?"

"Mak."

His voice was barely audible.

"What happened?"

"There's someone outside my room."

A pause.

"What?"

"Someone is standing outside the window."

His mother immediately became more alert.

"Don't open the curtains."

"I know."

"Stay there."

He heard her bedroom door open.

Then footsteps moved slowly through the hallway.

His bedroom door opened.

His mother switched on the light.

The shadow disappeared.

She looked toward the curtains.

"Where?"

He pointed.

She approached the window.

"Don't."

She stopped.

For a moment, neither of them moved.

Then she pulled the curtains open.

Nothing.

The window was locked.

Outside, the garden was empty.

The leaves were wet from earlier rain. A few drops fell from the branches, hitting the ground one after another.

His mother looked at him.

There was fear in her eyes.

But it wasn't fear of the window.

It was fear of him.

•

The following afternoon, they went to see the healer.

The house was tucked behind a row of old shops. There were several pairs of slippers outside the front door, wet from the morning rain.

Inside, the air smelled strongly of incense and something herbal.

A small fan turned slowly in the corner.

It wasn't enough to cool the room.

Several people sat quietly along the wall.

Nobody spoke loudly.

His mother explained what had happened.

The healer listened.

When she finished, he looked at him.

"How long have you been seeing her?"

He swallowed.

"Three nights."

The healer nodded.

"Only three?"

He looked up.

"What do you mean?"

The healer didn't answer immediately.

Instead, he asked:

"When did you first stop sleeping properly?"

He looked at his hands.

"I don't know."

"When did you first stop talking to people?"

Silence.

His mother looked at him.

The healer leaned forward.

"Something is troubling you."

He almost laughed.

Of course something was troubling him.

But that didn't mean there was a ghost.

That didn't mean something was following him.

That didn't mean he was

"She doesn't hurt me," he said.

The healer's eyes narrowed slightly.

"Who?"

"The woman."

His mother lowered her eyes.

The healer remained silent.

Then he asked:

"What does she say?"

He thought about it.

"Nothing."

"What does she want?"

"I don't know."

The healer leaned back.

"Perhaps you should ask her."

•

That night, he left the curtains open.

He didn't tell his mother.

The house was quiet.

Outside, the road was empty. A streetlight flickered occasionally, casting the trees in alternating patches of yellow and darkness.

He waited.

11:42.

12:18.

1:03.

Nothing.

His eyes grew heavy.

Maybe he had been imagining everything.

Maybe the healer was right about one thing.

Maybe he should simply ask.

At 3:17 a.m., she appeared.

Across the road.

Under the same tree.

White clothes.

Long dark hair.

Bare feet.

He stared at her.

This time, he didn't close the curtains.

He opened the window.

Cold air entered the room.

The woman didn't move.

"Who are you?"

Nothing.

He swallowed.

"What do you want?"

Still nothing.

Then she raised one hand.

She pointed at him.

No.

Not at him.

Behind him.

His breathing stopped.

He slowly turned around.

Nothing.

The room was empty.

He looked back toward the window.

The woman was gone.

He stood frozen.

Then he heard something.

A voice.

Very soft.

Very close.

"You're not supposed to be alone."

He turned.

Nobody was there.

His eyes filled with tears.

Not because he was afraid.

Because he suddenly realized he couldn't remember the last time
someone had said that to him.

•

The following morning, he told his mother everything.

Not about the woman.

Everything else.

He told her he hadn't been sleeping.

That he had stopped enjoying things.

That some mornings, getting out of bed felt impossible.

That he had been pretending to be okay at work.

That he was tired of telling everyone *nothing was wrong*.

His mother listened.

She didn't interrupt.

When he finished, the house was completely quiet.

Even the television was off.

Then she reached across the table and held his hand.

"You should have told me."

He looked at her.

"I didn't know how."

She squeezed his hand.

"Neither did I."

For the first time in months, he didn't say *okay*.

He simply nodded.

•

He stopped seeing the healer.

He began speaking to a professional instead.

It wasn't an instant cure.

Some nights were still difficult.

Some mornings were still heavy.

There were days when he felt as though he had taken one step forward only to fall three steps back.

But slowly, things became quieter.

Months later, he returned to his bedroom one evening.

Rain had started again.

He stood beside the window.

The same road.

The same tree.

The same orange streetlight.

For a moment, everything felt familiar.

He looked across the road.

There was a woman standing beneath the tree.

His heart stopped.

White clothes.

Long dark hair.

Bare feet.

He blinked.

The street was empty.

Only rain.

Only the streetlight.

Only his own reflection in the glass.

He looked at himself.

For a moment, he thought he saw someone standing behind him.

A woman.

Smiling.

He turned.

Nothing.

He looked back at the window.

His reflection was still there.

But this time, it wasn't smiling.

And neither was he.

He stood there for several seconds.

Then his reflection raised its hand.

He didn't.

His breath stopped.

Slowly, the reflection placed its palm against the glass.

He remained frozen.

The hand on the other side was pale.

Too pale.

He took one step backward.

The reflection didn't move.

Another step.

Still nothing.

Then the bedroom door creaked.

He turned.

The door was open.

The hallway beyond it was dark.

He looked back at the window.

His reflection was normal again.

He let out a shaky breath.

Maybe he was tired.

Maybe the lack of sleep was finally catching up with him.

Maybe there had never been a woman.

He walked toward the door.

Then he stopped.

Something was on the floor.

Wet footprints.

They began at the window.

One.

Two.

Three.

Four.

They continued across the bedroom.

And stopped beside his bed.

He stared at them.

The window was closed.

He hadn't opened it.

He slowly looked toward the glass.

His reflection was still standing there.

This time...

it was smiling.

Behind him, a woman's voice whispered:

"You're not supposed to be alone."

He turned.

Nothing.

Only the empty room.

Only the sound of rain.

And the faint clicking of the ceiling fan.

He looked back at the window.

His reflection was gone.

•

End of story 01.

02

THE HOUSE THAT PRAYED

Some families pray for the person.

Some pray for whatever they believe is inside them.

The first thing Aina noticed was the smell.

Burning incense.

It filled the small living room, mixing with the smell of rain that had entered through the open windows. The air was thick and warm, yet she couldn't stop shivering.

She sat on the floor with her back against the wall.

Her mother sat opposite her.

Between them was a plastic bowl filled with water.

A man she had never met before sat beside it.

He was wearing a white shirt and a black kopiah.

He looked at her for a long time.

Aina looked away.

"Look at me."

She didn't.

"Look at me, Aina."

She slowly raised her eyes.

The man's expression didn't change.

"When did it start?"

She swallowed.

"I don't know."

"Don't lie."

"I'm not."

Her mother's fingers tightened around the edge of her shawl.

The man leaned closer.

"Something is disturbing you."

Aina almost laughed.

She wanted to say:

I know.

But not the way he meant it.

•

For the past three months, Aina had been waking up tired.

Not sleepy.

Tired.

There was a difference.

Sleep didn't seem to help anymore.

She would wake at six in the morning with her body feeling as though she had spent the entire night carrying something heavy.

Her room was usually the warmest room in the house.

That morning, however, she had woken up freezing.

She had pulled the blanket around herself and sat on the edge of the bed.

The room was quiet.

Too quiet.

Then she heard her mother's voice.

"Aina."

She looked toward the bedroom door.

Nobody was there.

"Aina."

She opened the door.

The hallway was empty.

Her mother was downstairs.

She knew because she could hear plates being moved in the kitchen.

She had almost forgotten about it.

Until the voice came again.

From inside her room.

"Aina."

She turned.

Nothing.

•

After that, her mother began to worry.

Not because Aina told her she was hearing voices.

Aina didn't tell her.

She told her mother she wasn't sleeping.

Her mother asked if she was stressed.

Aina said yes.

"Because of work?"

"Maybe."

"Problems with friends?"

"No."

"Someone hurt you?"

Aina looked at her mother.

"No."

Her mother nodded.

Then she said something Aina would remember for a long time.

"You should pray more."

Aina stared at the floor.

"I know."

She did pray.

But lately, even prayer felt like another thing she was failing to do correctly.

•

The man sitting across from her now placed his fingers into the bowl of water.

He whispered something.

Aina couldn't understand the words.

Her mother watched him carefully.

The room suddenly felt colder.

Aina rubbed her arms.

The man looked at her.

"You feel cold?"

She nodded.

"When did it start?"

"Today."

He smiled.

Not kindly.

Like he had just received the answer he wanted.

"That's not your cold."

Aina looked at her mother.

Her mother lowered her eyes.

The man continued.

"There is something here."

Aina's stomach tightened.

"What?"

He looked toward the corner of the room.

Aina followed his gaze.

There was nothing there.

Only an old cabinet.

A calendar.

And a small crack in the wall.

"Something has been following you."

Her mother covered her mouth.

Aina closed her eyes.

She wanted to scream.

Instead, she whispered:

"I'm tired."

The man looked at her.

"That is because it is feeding from you."

•

The treatment lasted forty minutes.

He recited prayers.

He blew gently across the water.

He instructed Aina to drink it.

At one point, he asked her to close her eyes.

She did.

"Tell me what you see."

"Nothing."

"Look carefully."

She opened her eyes.

"Nothing."

The man sighed.

"Don't fight it."

"I'm not."

"You're afraid."

"Yes."

"Good."

Aina looked at him.

"Why is that good?"

"Because fear means you know something is there."

She didn't answer.

She wanted to leave.

But her mother was sitting beside her.

Watching.

Hoping.

So Aina stayed.

•

That night, she slept in her mother's room.

The house smelled of incense.

The fan above them turned slowly.

Outside, rain tapped against the window.

Her mother was already asleep.

Aina stared into the darkness.

She couldn't sleep.

Again, she heard her name.

"Aina."

Her eyes opened wider.

She didn't move.

"Aina."

This time, the voice came from the corner.

She turned her head.

Nothing.

Her mother's breathing was slow and steady beside her.

Aina pulled the blanket higher.

Then she heard footsteps.

One.

Two.

Three.

Slow steps across the room.

She closed her eyes.

The footsteps stopped beside the bed.

Aina held her breath.

Something touched the blanket near her feet.

She screamed.

Her mother woke immediately.

"What happened?"

Aina sat upright.

"Someone was here."

Her mother switched on the light.

The room was empty.

Her mother looked at her.

Then at the floor.

Then back at her.

"Did you dream?"

"No."

"Aina..."

"I'm awake."

Her mother sat beside her.

"Maybe you should sleep."

Aina looked at her.

"Mak, I'm scared."

Her mother hugged her.

"I know."

Aina closed her eyes.

For a moment, she felt safe.

Then her mother whispered:

"Don't worry. We'll get rid of it."

Aina opened her eyes.

She didn't correct her.

•

Over the next few weeks, the treatments continued.

Incense.

Water.

Prayers.

Salt.

Oil.

Different rooms.

Different nights.

Different people.

Everyone had an explanation.

Someone said the house had something attached to it.

Someone else said Aina had disturbed something.

Another person said she was too sensitive.

Nobody asked her why she was sad.

Nobody asked why she stopped answering messages.

Nobody asked why she cried in the bathroom every morning before work.

They only asked:

"What did you see?"

And every time she answered:

"Nothing."

They became more convinced that she was hiding something.

•

One evening, Aina finally broke.

She was sitting alone in her bedroom when her mother entered.

"Tomorrow we're going again."

Aina didn't answer.

"Did you hear me?"

"Yes."

"Don't make that face."

Aina looked up.

"What face?"

"That face."

Her mother sounded frustrated.

"We're trying to help you."

Aina stared at her.

"I know."

"Then cooperate."

"I am cooperating."

"You're not."

Something inside Aina cracked.

"I don't want another treatment."

Her mother froze.

"What?"

"I don't want to go."

"Why?"

"Because I'm not possessed."

Silence.

Her mother stared at her.

"Then what's wrong with you?"

Aina opened her mouth.

Nothing came out.

Her eyes filled with tears.

"I don't know."

Her mother looked away.

"Exactly."

Aina wiped her face.

"I think I need help."

"We are helping you."

"No."

She shook her head.

"I mean... real help."

Her mother didn't understand.

Or perhaps she didn't want to.

•

That night, Aina locked her bedroom door.

For the first time in weeks, there was no incense.

No prayers from downstairs.

No footsteps outside.

Just darkness.

She sat on her bed.

Her breathing slowly became steady.

Then she heard the voice again.

"Aina."

She froze.

The room was silent.

"Aina."

The voice came from behind her.

She slowly turned.

Nothing.

Her heart began to race.

She looked toward the bedroom door.

Still locked.

Then she heard something beside her.

A whisper.

"You don't need them."

Aina stopped breathing.

The voice continued.

"You only need me."

She closed her eyes.

Tears rolled down her cheeks.

For a moment, she wanted to believe it.

Because the voice was the only thing that had stayed with her.

Even when everyone else had stopped listening.

•

The next morning, her mother found her sitting on the floor.

The room was cold.

The window was open.

Rain had entered during the night.

Her mother rushed toward her.

"Aina!"

Aina looked up.

Her face was calm.

Too calm.

"Mak."

"What happened?"

Aina smiled.

"Nothing."

Her mother touched her forehead.

"You were talking last night."

Aina's smile disappeared.

"What did I say?"

Her mother hesitated.

"You kept saying the same thing."

"What?"

Her mother looked toward the open window.

Then back at her daughter.

"You said..."

She swallowed.

"She's my mother now."

Aina stared at her.

"I don't remember saying that."

Her mother stepped backward.

Aina looked toward the window.

The curtains moved gently in the morning wind.

For just a second, she thought she saw someone standing outside.

A woman.

Watching.

Smiling.

Aina blinked.

Nothing.

She looked back at her mother.

"Mak?"

Her mother didn't answer.

She was staring at the floor.

There were wet footprints beside Aina's bed.

They weren't Aina's.

They were too small.

And they led from the window...

to her mother's side of the bed.

•

End of Story 02.

03

THE MAN WHO WASN'T SICK

Some people hide their pain.

Some people hide behind it.

The police station smelled of old paper, instant coffee, and rain.

Daniel sat alone on a plastic chair near the wall.

His shirt was still damp from the weather outside. The air-conditioning was too cold, and every few minutes, someone walked past carrying a stack of documents.

He kept his head down.

Across the room, a police officer was speaking quietly with his lawyer.

Daniel listened without looking at them.

"...the statement is still being reviewed."

His lawyer nodded.

Then the officer looked toward Daniel.

"Mr. Daniel."

Daniel raised his head.

"Yes?"

"Do you understand why you're here?"

Daniel stared at him.

His expression changed.

Confusion.

Fear.

Then something almost childlike.

"I don't remember."

The officer looked at his lawyer.

Daniel lowered his eyes again.

He had practiced that sentence all morning.

•

Three days earlier, Daniel had been at a restaurant.

There had been an argument.

A serious one.

Someone had ended up in hospital.

Daniel remembered everything.

The shouting.

The glass breaking.

The sound of someone falling.

The blood on the floor.

He remembered leaving.

He remembered driving home.

He remembered washing his hands.

He remembered looking at himself in the bathroom mirror.

And thinking:

I'm in trouble.

He had spent the entire night searching for answers on his phone.

What happens if someone cannot remember what they did?

What if someone is mentally unstable?

What if someone has a disorder?

What if they cannot control themselves?

The internet gave him hundreds of possibilities.

Daniel kept reading.

Then he found something useful.

A diagnosis could change how people saw you.

Not guilty.

Not responsible.

Not dangerous.

Just...

Sick.

He smiled at the screen.

And began learning.

•

At first, Daniel told his lawyer he had been depressed for years.

Then he said he had anxiety.

Then he said there were periods when he felt detached from reality.

His lawyer asked if he had ever been diagnosed.

Daniel shook his head.

"No."

That was important.

He didn't want a diagnosis.

Not yet.

He wanted uncertainty.

Uncertainty gave people room to imagine the worst.

During the police interview, he became quiet.

He stared at the floor.

Sometimes he rubbed his hands together.

Sometimes he asked the same question twice.

When the officer showed him photographs from the restaurant, Daniel looked away.

"I don't remember."

The officer placed another photograph in front of him.

"Do you recognize this person?"

Daniel stared at it.

His eyes became wet.

"I don't know."

The officer leaned back.

"Daniel, you were there."

Daniel covered his face.

"I'm sorry."

The interview stopped.

His lawyer touched his shoulder.

"That's enough for today."

Daniel nodded.

Inside, he felt relieved.

It was working.

•

A week later, Daniel was sitting in a hospital waiting room.

The walls were pale.

The lights were bright.

The air smelled faintly of disinfectant.

A clock above the reception desk ticked loudly.

He hated hospitals.

Not because they frightened him.

Because they reminded him that real sick people were everywhere.

A nurse called his name.

"Daniel?"

He stood.

The psychiatrist welcomed him into a small consultation room.

There were two chairs, a desk, a computer, and a window overlooking the car park.

The doctor sat down.

Daniel remained standing for a moment.

Then slowly took his seat.

"How have you been sleeping?"

Daniel looked down.

"Not well."

"How many hours?"

"Maybe three."

"Every night?"

Daniel nodded.

The doctor typed something.

"How have you been feeling?"

Daniel hesitated.

"Empty."

The doctor looked at him.

"Can you explain what you mean?"

Daniel had prepared for this.

"I don't feel anything."

"Nothing?"

"Sometimes I feel like I'm watching myself from outside."

The doctor paused.

"When did that start?"

Daniel looked toward the window.

"I don't know."

That answer was safe.

"I see."

The doctor wrote something down.

Then asked:

"Do you hear voices?"

Daniel's heart skipped.

He hadn't expected that.

He looked back at the doctor.

"Sometimes."

"Do they speak directly to you?"

Daniel nodded.

"What do they say?"

He thought for a moment.

"They tell me things."

"What kind of things?"

Daniel lowered his voice.

"Bad things."

The doctor didn't react.

Daniel realized something.

This wasn't going to be as easy as he thought.

•

The sessions continued.

Daniel learned quickly.

Too quickly.

He learned which words made doctors ask more questions.

He learned when to cry.

When to become silent.

When to look confused.

When to say:

"I don't know."

He discovered that people trusted sadness.

They trusted silence.

They trusted someone who looked exhausted.

And Daniel became very good at looking exhausted.

Outside the hospital, his friends began treating him differently.

One stopped asking about the incident.

Another told people:

"He's not himself right now."

Someone else said:

"You have to understand. He's mentally unwell."

Daniel never corrected them.

Why would he?

•

Three months passed.

The case became complicated.

Daniel was not released.

But he wasn't treated like an ordinary criminal either.

His lawyer told him that the psychiatric reports were helping.

"You need to continue cooperating."

Daniel nodded.

"I will."

"You need to be consistent."

Daniel smiled faintly.

"I understand."

The lawyer left.

Daniel sat alone in the consultation room.

For the first time, he looked tired.

Not because he was mentally ill.

Because pretending to be someone else for three months was exhausting.

He looked at his reflection in the dark computer screen.

He smiled.

Then stopped.

There was something wrong with the reflection.

It looked tired.

More tired than he felt.

Daniel leaned closer.

The reflection whispered:

"You're not sick."

He stepped backward.

The screen was black.

Nothing.

He laughed nervously.

"Too much time here."

•

The next session was different.

The psychiatrist closed the file.

"Daniel."

He looked up.

"Yes?"

"I want to ask you something."

"Okay."

"Do you believe you're mentally ill?"

Daniel remained silent.

Then nodded.

"Yes."

The doctor watched him carefully.

"Why?"

Daniel frowned.

"What do you mean?"

"Why do you believe that?"

"Because I've been feeling this way."

The doctor nodded.

"That's what you say."

Daniel's expression changed.

The room suddenly felt colder.

"What does that mean?"

The doctor opened another file.

"You've given several different accounts of your symptoms."

Daniel stared at her.

"People's memories change."

"They do."

She turned a page.

"But your symptoms change depending on what you think I want to hear."

Daniel didn't answer.

The doctor continued.

"You said you couldn't sleep."

"I can't."

"You told another doctor you sleep ten hours."

"I was confused."

"You said you heard voices."

"I do."

"You described them differently each time."

Daniel's hands tightened around the chair.

The doctor looked directly at him.

"Daniel, I don't think you're experiencing what you claim to be experiencing."

Silence.

He swallowed.

"Are you saying I'm lying?"

"I'm asking you."

The room seemed suddenly very small.

Daniel looked toward the window.

Rain had started outside.

Tiny drops slid down the glass.

He could hear the air-conditioning.

The ticking clock.

His own breathing.

Then he smiled.

A small smile.

Almost invisible.

"Maybe."

The doctor didn't smile back.

•

That evening, Daniel's lawyer visited him.

He looked serious.

"The psychiatrist submitted a new report."

Daniel said nothing.

"She believes you're exaggerating your symptoms."

Daniel leaned back.

"Can they prove that?"

His lawyer didn't answer immediately.

"That's not the point."

"It is to me."

"Daniel."

His lawyer lowered his voice.

"You need to stop."

Daniel stared at him.

"Stop what?"

"Whatever you're doing."

For the first time, Daniel looked genuinely angry.

"You think I'm pretending?"

"I think you know exactly what you're doing."

Daniel stood.

"Then prove it."

His lawyer stared at him.

Daniel smiled.

"I'll see you in court."

•

That night, Daniel returned to his room.

The corridor was quiet.

The fluorescent lights hummed above him.

He entered his room and closed the door.

For several minutes, he stood in darkness.

Then he looked at the small mirror above the sink.

His reflection stared back.

He smiled.

The reflection didn't.

Daniel stopped.

He waited.

Slowly, the reflection raised its hand.

Daniel didn't.

His smile disappeared.

The reflection moved closer to the glass.

Its lips opened.

Daniel heard a whisper.

"You keep pretending."

He stepped backward.

"No."

The reflection smiled.

"You weren't pretending that night."

Daniel froze.

The room seemed to lose all its warmth.

"What?"

The reflection leaned closer.

"You remember everything."

Daniel stared at it.

He suddenly remembered the restaurant.

The argument.

The glass.

The sound of someone hitting the floor.

The blood.

And then something else.

Something he had forgotten.

Someone had whispered to him that night.

Not a voice in his head.

A real voice.

Right beside his ear.

"Run."

Daniel stumbled backward.

The mirror cracked.

A thin line appeared across the glass.

Then another.

Then another.

His reflection remained perfectly intact.

Smiling.

Daniel stared at it.

"No..."

The reflection whispered:

"You're not sick."

A pause.

"You just wanted everyone to believe you were."

The lights went out.

In the darkness, Daniel heard footsteps behind him.

One.

Two.

Three.

Then a voice.

The same voice from the restaurant.

Right beside his ear.

"Now you remember."

•

End of Story 03.

04

THE ROOM AT THE END OF THE HALL

Some rooms are locked for a reason.

Some doors are kept closed because people are afraid of what they remember.

The first time Farid noticed the door, it was already open.

He had lived in the house for eleven years.

He knew every room.

The kitchen with the loose tap.

The living room where his father used to sleep after coming home late.

His sister's old bedroom, which had remained untouched since she moved away.

And the small room at the end of the upstairs hallway.

That room had always been locked.

Always.

He remembered asking about it when he was a child.

His mother had simply said:

"Don't go inside."

He never asked again.

Until that Thursday night.

The house was unusually quiet.

His wife had gone to her mother's house with their daughter for the weekend, leaving Farid alone.

Rain had been falling since evening.

The kind of rain that made the whole house feel smaller.

At 1:26 a.m., Farid woke to the sound of something falling upstairs.

He sat up.

The bedroom was dark except for the weak blue light from his phone.

For a moment, he listened.

Nothing.

Then—

Bang.

Another sound.

He got out of bed.

The floor was cold beneath his feet.

He opened the bedroom door.

The hallway light was off.

At the far end of the hallway, the door was open.

Farid stopped breathing.

The room at the end of the hall was open.

He stood there for several seconds.

Then he whispered:

"Mak?"

Nobody answered.

His mother had been dead for six years.

He knew that.

He still said her name.

•

The next morning, Farid called his older brother.

"Did you open the room upstairs?"

His brother was silent.

"What room?"

"The small room."

Another silence.

"You went inside?"

"No."

"Don't."

Farid frowned.

"Why?"

His brother sighed.

"You know why."

"No, I don't."

"Farid."

"What?"

"Just close the door."

Farid looked toward the staircase.

"What's inside?"

His brother didn't answer.

Then he said:

"Nothing you need to know."

•

Farid waited until afternoon.

Then he went upstairs.

The door was still open.

The hallway smelled of dust.

Sunlight entered through the small window at the end of the corridor, illuminating tiny particles floating in the air.

He stood outside the room.

The temperature felt different.

Cooler.

He reached for the handle.

Then stopped.

His mother's voice came back to him.

Don't go inside.

He opened the door.

The room was almost empty.

An old wooden chair.

A broken cupboard.

A mattress covered with a white sheet.

And photographs.

Dozens of them.

Farid stepped inside.

The wooden floor creaked beneath him.

He picked up the first photograph.

It was old.

His mother was standing in front of the house.

Beside her was a young woman Farid didn't recognize.

He turned the photograph over.

There was writing on the back.

1978.

He picked up another.

His mother.

The same woman.

Another photograph.

His mother.

The same woman.

Another.

His mother.

But the woman was gone.

Farid frowned.

Then he saw the last photograph.

His stomach dropped.

It was a picture of him.

Standing in front of the house.

He was maybe seven years old.

He was smiling.

But someone had written something across the photograph.

Three words.

HE WILL RETURN.

Farid dropped it.

•

That evening, his brother arrived.

The moment he entered the house, he went upstairs.

Farid followed.

His brother stopped outside the room.

"You opened it."

"Yes."

"Why?"

"Because I wanted to know."

His brother closed his eyes.

"You shouldn't have."

"Who was she?"

He didn't answer.

"Who was she?"

His brother finally looked at him.

"Our sister."

Farid stared at him.

"What?"

"Our older sister."

Farid laughed.

"No."

"You were too young."

"I don't have an older sister."

"You did."

Farid shook his head.

"Why don't I remember her?"

His brother looked toward the room.

"Because you weren't supposed to."

•

That night, Farid couldn't sleep.

The rain had stopped.

The house was silent.

He lay awake beside the empty side of the bed.

At 2:11 a.m., he heard footsteps upstairs.

Slow.

Bare feet against wood.

He sat up.

The footsteps stopped.

Then came three knocks.

From the ceiling.

Farid switched on the light.

Nothing.

He walked upstairs.

The hallway was dark.

The door at the end was closed.

He hadn't closed it.

He was certain.

He approached it.

The air became colder.

He placed his hand on the door.

Three knocks came from the other side.

Farid pulled his hand away.

Then he heard a voice.

A woman's voice.

Soft.

Almost familiar.

"Farid."

He couldn't move.

"Farid."

His throat tightened.

"Who are you?"

Silence.

Then:

"You forgot me."

The door slowly opened.

Inside, the room was dark.

The mattress was empty.

The chair was empty.

The photographs were gone.

Farid stepped backward.

Something touched his shoulder.

He turned.

Nobody.

His heart hammered against his chest.

Then he heard laughter from inside the room.

A child's laughter.

His own.

•

The next morning, Farid found an old box in his mother's cupboard.

Inside were documents.

Birth certificates.

Old letters.

Photographs.

And one newspaper clipping.

He unfolded it.

The paper was yellow with age.

The headline made his hands tremble.

LOCAL GIRL DIES IN HOUSE FIRE

Below the headline was a photograph.

The same woman.

Farid sat down.

He read the article.

The fire had happened forty years ago.

A child had been trapped inside the house.

Her younger brother had survived.

Farid stared at the date.

Then at the photograph.

Then at his own hands.

His brother entered the room.

Farid looked up.

"Why didn't you tell me?"

His brother said nothing.

"Why?"

"Because Mum didn't want you to remember."

"Remember what?"

His brother looked exhausted.

"You were the one who caused the fire."

Farid froze.

"No."

"You were seven."

"No."

"You were playing with matches."

Farid shook his head.

"No."

"You didn't mean to."

"No."

"You don't remember because Mum spent years making sure you didn't."

Farid stood.

"You knew?"

His brother looked away.

"I was there."

The room became silent.

Farid's breathing grew heavier.

Suddenly, fragments began appearing in his mind.

A match.

A curtain.

Smoke.

His sister screaming.

His mother's hands around his shoulders.

Someone shouting:

RUN!

Farid stumbled backward.

The house seemed to tilt around him.

He grabbed the table.

Then he heard a sound from upstairs.

A door opening.

His brother looked up.

Both men stared toward the ceiling.

Slow footsteps.

One.

Two.

Three.

His brother whispered:

"She's back."

Farid shook his head.

"She's been here."

The footsteps stopped.

Then a little girl's voice called from upstairs.

"Farid?"

He closed his eyes.

The voice continued.

"Why did you leave me?"

His brother grabbed his arm.

"Don't answer."

Farid looked at him.

"What happens if I do?"

His brother's face had gone pale.

"I don't know."

The room at the end of the hallway slowly opened.

Farid could see the darkness beyond it.

Then something rolled out.

A small red toy car.

It stopped at the top of the stairs.

Farid stared at it.

He remembered that toy.

He had played with it the day of the fire.

His sister had taken it from him.

He had gotten angry.

He had lit the match.

Then the fire.

Then screaming.

Then running.

He remembered everything.

Farid began to cry.

"I'm sorry."

The house became silent.

His brother looked at him.

"Farid..."

The voice came again.

Closer this time.

"Say it properly."

Farid looked toward the stairs.

"I was scared."

Nothing.

"I didn't know what to do."

The lights flickered.

"I left you."

A cold wind moved through the house.

Then:

"You did."

The hallway light went out.

Farid heard footsteps coming down the stairs.

Slowly.

One step at a time.

He couldn't see anyone.

But he could hear breathing.

His brother stepped backward.

Farid remained still.

Then a small hand appeared around the corner.

A child's hand.

Blackened at the fingertips.

Farid stared.

The hand disappeared.

The footsteps stopped.

The house became completely silent.

His brother whispered:

"Farid."

"What?"

"Look behind you."

Farid slowly turned.

His mother was standing at the end of the hallway.

She had been dead for six years.

She looked exactly as he remembered her.

Except for the burns covering half her face.

She smiled.

And beside her stood the little girl from the photographs.

His sister.

The woman who had died forty years ago.

She looked at Farid.

Not angrily.

Not sadly.

Just tired.

Then she whispered:

"You finally remembered."

The door at the end of the hallway slammed shut.

•

End of Story 04.

05

THE MAN IN ROOM 17

They were afraid of what he might become.

They never asked what had happened to him.

The corridor smelled of antiseptic.

It was the first thing Amir noticed when he opened his eyes.

The second was the cold.

The air-conditioning was turned low enough that he could feel it against his skin. He pulled the thin blanket closer to his chest and looked around the room.

White walls.

A narrow window.

A metal bed.

A plastic chair.

And a small clock above the door.

2:43 a.m.

He didn't remember falling asleep.

He remembered shouting.

Then his brother.

Then the ambulance.

Then the ceiling of the emergency department moving above him.

After that—

Nothing.

He tried to sit up.

The room spun.

He closed his eyes.

"Don't."

A voice came from the doorway.

A nurse was standing there.

She stepped inside.

"Lie down."

Amir looked at her.

"Where am I?"

She hesitated.

"Hospital."

"I know that."

She pulled the chair closer.

"You're in the psychiatric ward."

Amir stared at her.

For a moment, he couldn't understand the words.

Then he laughed.

"I'm not crazy."

The nurse didn't react.

"I didn't say you were."

Amir looked away.

The clock continued ticking.

•

Three days earlier, Amir had been at home.

He had not slept properly for almost two weeks.

His mother noticed first.

"You look tired."

"I'm fine."

"You've been saying that every day."

"I'm fine, Mak."

He wasn't.

He knew it.

But he didn't know how to explain it.

His thoughts had become loud.

Not voices.

Thoughts.

Too many of them.

Every mistake he'd ever made seemed to return at night.

Every conversation became something he replayed.

Why did I say that?

What if they hate me?

What if I lose my job?

What if something happens to Mum?

Sometimes he would sit in the living room until morning because he was afraid to sleep.

One night, his mother found him standing in the kitchen at 4 a.m.

"What are you doing?"

"Nothing."

"You've been standing there for twenty minutes."

He looked at the clock.

He hadn't realized.

"I'm just thinking."

His mother touched his arm.

"Come sleep."

"I can't."

"Why?"

He didn't know how to answer.

So he said:

"I'm scared."

His mother looked at him.

"Of what?"

Amir stared into the dark kitchen.

"Everything."

•

His brother came the following afternoon.

His mother had called him.

They sat together in the living room.

The ceiling fan turned slowly above them.

Outside, children were playing in the street.

Amir's brother leaned forward.

"Have you been taking your medication?"

Amir frowned.

"I don't take medication."

His brother exchanged a look with their mother.

"That's what I'm talking about."

"I don't have anything."

"You need to see someone."

"I already said I'm fine."

His brother sighed.

"You don't look fine."

Amir stood.

"I said I'm fine."

His voice was louder than he intended.

The room went quiet.

His mother flinched.

Amir immediately regretted it.

"Sorry."

He walked toward his bedroom.

Behind him, he heard his brother whisper:

"He's getting worse."

Amir stopped.

He didn't turn around.

He went into his room and closed the door.

•

That night, he heard them talking.

His mother.

His brother.

They were whispering downstairs.

He couldn't hear everything.

Only fragments.

"...can't keep going like this..."

"...dangerous..."

"...what if he hurts himself?"

Amir sat on his bed.

His chest tightened.

Dangerous.

The word stayed in his head.

He wasn't dangerous.

He was tired.

He was scared.

He needed someone to listen.

Instead, everyone was beginning to look at him as though he was something that needed to be contained.

•

The next morning, his brother took him to a clinic.

The waiting room was crowded.

Children were crying.

An elderly man was coughing.

A television played quietly from the corner.

Amir sat between his mother and brother.

Nobody spoke.

When his name was called, he stood.

The doctor asked him questions.

How long had he been feeling this way?

Had he been sleeping?

Had he thought about hurting himself?

Had he heard voices?

Had he ever felt that someone was watching him?

Amir answered honestly.

"No."

"Do you want to hurt yourself?"

"No."

"Anyone else?"

"No."

The doctor looked at his notes.

"Then why did your family bring you here?"

Amir looked through the window.

His mother and brother were waiting outside.

"Because they're afraid of me."

The doctor looked at him.

"Are you afraid of yourself?"

Amir thought about it.

"No."

The doctor nodded.

"That's important."

But when Amir walked back into the waiting room, his brother stood immediately.

"What's the doctor saying?"

Amir didn't answer.

His brother looked at the doctor.

The doctor said:

"He needs support."

His brother nodded.

"Of course."

But Amir noticed something.

His brother didn't look relieved.

He looked frightened.

•

That evening, Amir's condition became worse.

Not because he was hallucinating.

Not because he became violent.

Because he finally broke down.

He sat on the kitchen floor and cried.

He couldn't stop.

His mother tried to hold him.

His brother called the clinic.

Someone called an ambulance.

Amir kept saying:

"I just want it to stop."

The paramedics arrived.

They asked him questions.

He couldn't answer.

He was crying too hard.

One of them told him:

"We're going to take you somewhere safe."

Amir nodded.

He didn't fight.

He was tired.

•

Now he was in Room 17.

The nurse checked his pulse.

"You should try to sleep."

Amir looked at her.

"How long do I have to stay here?"

"We'll see."

"Can I go home?"

"Not yet."

He stared at the ceiling.

"Do people think I'm dangerous?"

The nurse paused.

"Some people are afraid because they don't understand."

Amir smiled sadly.

"I don't understand either."

She didn't know what to say.

So she left.

The door closed.

Amir was alone again.

•

At 3:17 a.m., he heard knocking.

Three slow knocks.

He sat up.

The corridor outside was dark.

A small light above the door flickered.

Knock.

Knock.

Knock.

Amir looked toward the door.

"Hello?"

No answer.

He got out of bed.

The floor was cold.

He walked closer.

The knocking stopped.

He placed his hand against the door.

Then he heard a whisper.

"Amir."

He froze.

The voice was coming from the corridor.

"Amir."

He opened the door.

The corridor was empty.

At the far end was a window.

Rain covered the glass.

The hallway lights flickered.

Amir stepped outside.

"Who's there?"

Nothing.

He walked slowly.

Room 14.

Room 15.

Room 16.

Then Room 17.

His room.

He stopped.

He looked back toward the door.

It was open.

Then he noticed something.

There was another door directly opposite his.

A door he hadn't noticed before.

Room 18.

A thin line of light came from underneath it.

Amir walked toward it.

He placed his hand on the handle.

A voice whispered from inside.

"Don't."

He froze.

The voice sounded exactly like his own.

He slowly opened the door.

Inside was another hospital room.

Another bed.

Another chair.

Another window.

And someone was sitting on the bed.

Amir stared.

It was him.

The other Amir looked exhausted.

Pale.

Terrified.

He stared back.

"Who are you?"

The other Amir smiled sadly.

"I'm the one they think you are."

Amir stepped backward.

"What?"

"They think you're dangerous."

"No."

"They think you're broken."

"No."

"They think you're sick."

Amir's hands began shaking.

The other Amir looked toward the door.

"They don't care which one is true."

The lights flickered.

Amir blinked.

The room was empty.

There was no second bed.

No second Amir.

Only an empty room.

He stepped backward.

Then he heard footsteps behind him.

A nurse.

She looked at him.

"What are you doing here?"

Amir couldn't speak.

She looked toward Room 18.

Her face changed.

"What room?"

He pointed.

"There."

She stared at the wall.

There was no door.

Only a blank white wall.

Amir's heart began pounding.

"I just..."

The nurse grabbed his arm.

"Come back to your room."

He pulled away.

"Did you see it?"

"See what?"

"The room."

She looked at him.

For a moment, there was something strange in her expression.

Fear.

Not concern.

Fear.

"Amir."

"What?"

She lowered her voice.

"Don't talk about Room 18."

He stared at her.

"Why?"

She looked down the corridor.

Then whispered:

"Because there hasn't been a Room 18 in twenty years."

•

The next morning, Amir asked about it.

Nobody answered.

His mother came to visit.

She brought food.

His brother came too.

They sat beside his bed.

His mother touched his hand.

"How are you?"

Amir looked at her.

"I'm okay."

She smiled.

His brother looked relieved.

For the first time in weeks, Amir felt calm.

Maybe things would get better.

Maybe he really could go home.

Then his mother asked:

"Did you sleep?"

Amir nodded.

"Mostly."

His brother looked at the nurse.

"Any problems?"

The nurse shook her head.

"Nothing."

Amir looked toward the door.

He suddenly remembered the night before.

Room 18.

The other Amir.

The warning.

He turned back to his family.

"Mak."

"Yes?"

"Have you ever heard of Room 18?"

His mother's smile disappeared.

His brother became completely still.

Neither of them answered.

Amir looked between them.

"What's wrong?"

His mother slowly stood.

"We should go."

"Why?"

His brother grabbed her arm.

"Don't."

Amir stared at them.

"What?"

His brother looked at him.

His face was pale.

"Where did you hear that?"

"Here."

"Who told you?"

"The nurse."

His brother looked toward the door.

Then whispered:

"There is no nurse named Sara."

Amir frowned.

"Yes, there is."

His brother shook his head.

"The nurse who has been looking after you..."

He stopped.

Amir waited.

His brother's voice became barely audible.

"She died twenty years ago."

Amir looked toward the corridor.

The lights flickered.

For a moment, he saw a woman standing outside Room 17.

White uniform.

Dark hair.

A gentle smile.

She raised one finger to her lips.

Then whispered through the glass:

"Don't let them convince you that you're sick."

The lights went out.

•

End of Story 05.

06

THE NAME THEY GAVE HER

*They called her possessed for so long,
she eventually stopped telling them she wasn't.*

The village was quiet after midnight.

Not peaceful.

Quiet.

There was a difference.

The rain had stopped almost an hour ago, but water still dripped from the leaves of the banana trees behind the house.

Nadia sat on the front steps.

The concrete was cold beneath her bare feet.

The night air was warm and damp, carrying the smell of wet soil and smoke from someone's dying fire.

She hadn't slept.

Again.

Inside the house, her mother was praying.

Nadia could hear the soft repetition of words through the thin wooden door.

She closed her eyes.

She was tired of hearing them.

Not the prayers.

The reason for them.

Her.

For the past six months, everyone in the village had believed something was wrong with Nadia.

At first, they said she was stressed.

Then they said she was depressed.

Then someone said she had changed.

Eventually, someone said:

"Something is following her."

And once that sentence was spoken aloud, everything changed.

•

It had started with a panic attack.

Nadia had been at work when her chest suddenly tightened.

Her hands became cold.

Her heart raced.

She couldn't breathe.

She thought she was dying.

Someone called her mother.

By the time she reached the clinic, she was shaking so badly that she could barely speak.

The doctor told her it was likely a panic attack.

Her mother didn't understand.

"Because of what?"

The doctor explained.

Stress.

Anxiety.

Lack of sleep.

Nadia nodded.

Her mother nodded too.

But on the drive home, she said:

"I don't think it's that."

Nadia looked out the window.

"What do you mean?"

Her mother didn't answer.

•

Three days later, they visited a traditional healer.

He didn't ask Nadia many questions.

He looked at her.

Then he looked at her mother.

Finally, he said:

"She brought something home."

Nadia frowned.

"What?"

He pointed toward the corner of the room.

Nadia looked.

Nothing.

"There's something attached to her."

Her mother whispered a prayer.

Nadia felt angry.

"There's nothing there."

The healer smiled.

"That's what they always say."

•

After that, people started watching her.

At the market, conversations stopped when she walked past.

Neighbours lowered their voices.

Children were told not to play near her house.

One woman crossed the road when she saw Nadia approaching.

Another told her mother:

"You should be careful."

Careful.

That word became another name for Nadia.

People were careful around her.

Careful when speaking.

Careful when touching her.

Careful when looking at her.

Eventually, Nadia stopped going outside.

•

Her mother tried everything.

Prayers.

Water.

Herbal baths.

Incense.

Different healers.

Different explanations.

Nadia stopped arguing.

There was no point.

Whenever she said:

"I'm not possessed."

They heard:

"She's hiding it."

Whenever she said:

"I'm just tired."

They heard:

"It is making her weak."

Whenever she cried.

They heard:

"Something is leaving her."

Her suffering had become evidence.

Everything she did proved their theory.

•

One evening, Nadia was sitting in the kitchen.

Her mother was preparing tea.

The kettle began to whistle.

Nadia stared at the steam.

"Mak."

Her mother didn't look up.

"Yes?"

"I think I need to see someone."

"A healer?"

"No."

Her mother stopped.

"A doctor."

Silence.

"I already took you to the doctor."

"Once."

"And he said nothing was wrong."

Nadia looked at her.

"He didn't say nothing was wrong."

"What did he say?"

"He said I was struggling."

Her mother shook her head.

"You don't understand."

"I understand perfectly."

Her mother's voice became softer.

"We're trying to protect you."

"From what?"

Her mother didn't answer.

Nadia looked down.

"From me?"

•

That night, Nadia woke at 2:08 a.m.

Her room was dark.

The fan above her turned slowly.

She could hear insects outside.

She sat up.

Someone was standing beside her bed.

She froze.

A woman.

Long hair.

White dress.

Head lowered.

Nadia couldn't breathe.

The figure slowly raised its head.

Nadia screamed.

Her mother rushed into the room.

"What happened?"

Nadia pointed.

"There!"

Her mother looked.

Nothing.

Nadia was shaking.

"She was here."

Her mother stared at her.

Then she whispered:

"What did she look like?"

Nadia described her.

Her mother covered her mouth.

"What?"

Her mother didn't answer.

"What?"

"I saw her too."

Nadia stared.

"You did?"

Her mother nodded slowly.

"Years ago."

Nadia's fear changed.

Maybe they had been right.

Maybe there really was something in the house.

•

The next morning, the healer returned.

He listened to Nadia's story.

Then he smiled.

"She's showing herself now."

Nadia looked at him.

"Who?"

"The one following you."

"Why?"

"Because you're getting weaker."

Nadia's mother started crying.

The healer told Nadia to sit down.

He placed a bowl of water in front of her.

"Look into it."

Nadia did.

The surface trembled.

At first, she saw only her own reflection.

Then the face changed.

A woman's face appeared.

Nadia screamed.

The bowl fell.

Water spread across the floor.

The healer stood immediately.

"Don't look at it!"

Nadia stumbled backward.

The woman was gone.

The room was silent.

The healer looked at Nadia.

"Now you understand."

Nadia stared at the broken bowl.

For the first time...

she believed him.

•

After that, Nadia changed.

She stopped fighting.

When people asked if she was possessed, she stopped saying no.

She simply looked at them.

Sometimes she smiled.

Sometimes she whispered to herself.

Sometimes she sat alone in the dark.

People became more afraid.

They said the spirit was getting stronger.

But nobody noticed something else.

Nadia had stopped asking for help.

•

One afternoon, her younger cousin came to see her.

He was twelve.

He sat beside her in the garden.

"Are you really possessed?"

Nadia looked at him.

"Why?"

"Everyone says you are."

She smiled.

"Do you believe them?"

He shook his head.

"Then why are you scared?"

He thought about it.

"Because everyone else is."

Nadia looked toward the house.

That sentence hurt more than anything anyone had said to her.

•

That night, Nadia sat in front of the mirror.

The room was dark except for a small lamp beside her bed.

She stared at her reflection.

Her face looked tired.

Her eyes were swollen.

She whispered:

"Who are you?"

The reflection remained silent.

She leaned closer.

"Are you real?"

Nothing.

Nadia closed her eyes.

When she opened them again, the woman was standing behind her.

She turned.

Nobody.

She looked back at the mirror.

The woman was there.

Nadia stared.

For the first time, she wasn't afraid.

"What do you want?"

The woman's mouth moved.

But no sound came.

Nadia leaned closer.

Then she heard it.

A whisper.

Not from the mirror.

From inside her own head.

"They gave me your name."

Nadia froze.

"What?"

The woman smiled.

"They needed something to blame."

The mirror cracked.

A thin line spread across Nadia's reflection.

She touched the glass.

"Are you the reason I'm like this?"

The woman shook her head.

"No."

"Then what are you?"

The woman looked behind Nadia.

Nadia turned.

Her bedroom door was open.

Her mother stood outside.

Her face was pale.

She was crying.

"Mak?"

Her mother whispered:

"Don't listen to her."

Nadia looked back at the mirror.

The woman was gone.

Only Nadia remained.

•

The next morning, Nadia disappeared.

Her mother searched the house.

Her room was empty.

The front door was unlocked.

Her shoes were still beside the bed.
Her phone was on the table.
Nobody knew where she had gone.
For three days, the village searched.
On the fourth morning, Nadia returned.
She walked into the house just before sunrise.
Her clothes were dirty.
Her hair was wet.
Her mother ran toward her.
"Where were you?"
Nadia said nothing.
Her mother grabbed her shoulders.
"Where?"
Nadia looked at her.
"I'm fine."
Her mother stared.
Something about Nadia had changed.
Not her face.
Not her voice.
Something else.
"Are you still seeing her?"

Nadia smiled.

"No."

Her mother exhaled.

"Thank God."

Nadia walked past her.

Then stopped.

Without turning around, she said:

"She doesn't need to follow me anymore."

Her mother froze.

"What?"

Nadia turned.

"Because now..."

She smiled.

"...they think I'm her."

Her mother stepped backward.

Nadia walked upstairs.

The hallway was empty.

The room at the end was dark.

She entered.

Closed the door.

And sat in front of the mirror.

Her reflection smiled before she did.

•

End of Story 06.

07

THE BOY EVERYONE BELIEVED

*He wanted people to believe he was broken.
He didn't expect them to believe him forever.*

The room was dark except for the light from his phone.

Adam lay on his bed with the curtains closed.

It was 1:48 a.m.

The air-conditioning hummed quietly above him, but the room still felt warm.

His phone screen illuminated his face.

He opened Instagram.

Typed.

Deleted.

Typed again.

Finally, he wrote:

I don't think I can do this anymore.

He stared at the sentence.

Then added:

Nobody knows what happens when the lights go off.

He took a photograph.

Not of himself.

Just the corner of his room.

Dark.

Empty.

Perfect.

He posted it.

Then waited.

•

The first notification arrived twelve seconds later.

Are you okay?

Adam smiled.

Another.

Please don't do anything stupid.

Another.

I'm here if you need someone.

He read them all.

His chest felt strangely warm.

Not sadness.

Something else.

Attention.

He posted another story.

A black screen.

Maybe tomorrow will be different.

Within minutes, people were messaging him.

Some were worried.

Some were sympathetic.

Some told him they understood.

Adam replied to almost everyone.

Thank you.

I'm trying.

It's hard.

You wouldn't understand.

The last one was his favourite.

It made people ask more questions.

•

It hadn't started like this.

At first, Adam really had been struggling.

He had been lonely.

He didn't like his university course.

His relationship had ended.

He felt lost.

But none of those things seemed serious enough to explain how he felt.

He watched other people online.

People talking openly about depression.

Anxiety.

Trauma.

Personality disorders.

Their posts received thousands of likes.

People sent them messages.

People cared.

Adam wanted that.

So he started copying them.

At first, it was harmless.

Quotes.

Sad songs.

Dark photographs.

Then he learned the language.

Dissociation.

Triggers.

Episodes.

Emotional numbness.

Personality disorder.

He didn't fully understand the words.

But he knew they made people listen.

•

A month later, Adam had become known among his friends as "the depressed one."

They checked on him.

They invited him out.

They asked if he had taken his medication.

Adam didn't take any.

But he never corrected them.

One evening, his friend Faris asked:

"Have you actually seen a psychiatrist?"

Adam shrugged.

"No."

"You should."

"I don't want to."

"Why?"

Adam looked away.

"I'm scared they'll tell me something I don't want to hear."

Faris nodded sympathetically.

Adam almost laughed.

He was getting very good at this.

•

Then Adam met Sara.

She was studying psychology.

Unlike everyone else, she didn't immediately believe him.

One evening, they sat outside a café.

The night air was humid.

Cars passed on the road, their headlights briefly illuminating the tables.

Sara stirred her drink.

"You've been saying you're depressed for almost a year."

Adam nodded.

"Yeah."

"Have you ever actually wanted to die?"

He looked at her.

"What kind of question is that?"

"A serious one."

Adam looked away.

"I don't know."

Sara watched him.

"You always say you don't know."

He smiled.

"It's complicated."

She didn't smile.

"Maybe."

A silence settled between them.

Then Sara asked:

"Do you want help?"

Adam hesitated.

"No."

"Why?"

He didn't have an answer.

Sara looked at him for a long moment.

Then said:

"Because I think you don't want to be better."

Adam frowned.

"That's not fair."

"Maybe."

She stood.

"But I think you like being seen as broken."

Adam watched her leave.

For the first time, he felt angry.

Not because she was wrong.

Because she was close.

•

Two weeks later, Adam posted a photograph of a handful of pills.

The caption was simple.

I'm tired.

His phone exploded with notifications.

People called him.

Friends came to his house.

Someone contacted his family.

An ambulance arrived.

Adam opened the door.

He was fine.

The pills weren't medication.

They were vitamins.

But by then, everyone was crying.

His mother hugged him.

His friend shouted at him.

The paramedic asked questions.

Adam sat silently.

Looking broken.

Looking exhausted.

Looking exactly how he imagined someone in crisis should look.

Later that night, he posted:

Sorry.

Thousands of people responded.

He felt powerful.

•

But something changed after that.

People began watching him.

Not admiring him.

Watching him.

His friends stopped leaving him alone.

His mother checked his room.

His phone was taken away at night.

He couldn't go anywhere without someone asking:

"Are you okay?"

At first, he enjoyed it.

Then it became exhausting.

He tried to tell them he was fine.

Nobody believed him.

"I'm okay."

"Are you sure?"

"Yes."

"You're not yourself."

"I'm fine."

"Don't lie."

Adam began to realize something.

He had created a version of himself that nobody trusted.

Not even when he told the truth.

•

One night, he deleted all his posts.

Every photograph.

Every sad quote.

Every message.

Every story.

He put his phone down.

The room felt strangely empty.

No notifications.

No messages.

No one asking if he was okay.

He stared at the ceiling.

For the first time in years, nobody was watching.

He felt nothing.

Then his phone vibrated.

One message.

From an unknown account.

Why did you delete everything?

Adam ignored it.

Another message.

We liked you better when you were broken.

He frowned.

He blocked the account.

The phone vibrated again.

Another account.

Same message.

He turned the phone off.

The room became silent.

Then he heard a notification sound.

From the phone.

Even though it was turned off.

Adam stared at it.

Another notification.

Then another.

He picked it up.

The screen turned on by itself.

Instagram opened.

A new story had been posted from his account.

Adam hadn't posted anything.
The photograph showed his bedroom.
Taken from the corner.
He was lying on the bed.
His face was visible.
But he hadn't taken the photograph.
The caption read:

I'm still here.

Adam's hands began to shake.
He deleted the story.
It returned.
He deleted it again.
It returned.

Then another story appeared.
A photograph of his bedroom door.
Closed.

Caption:

They're coming.

Adam sat upright.
The door was still closed.
He looked at his phone.

Another story.

The same door.

Closer.

Another.

Closer.

Another.

Until the final photograph showed the door from directly in front.

Then—

Knock.

Adam froze.

Someone knocked on his bedroom door.

Three times.

Knock.

Knock.

Knock.

He couldn't move.

His phone vibrated.

A new message appeared.

From the same unknown account.

You wanted people to believe you.

Adam stared at the screen.

Another message appeared.

Now someone does.

The bedroom door slowly opened.

Adam screamed.

The hallway was empty.

He grabbed his phone.

The camera was open.

He looked at the screen.

Someone was standing behind him.

Adam turned.

Nothing.

He looked back at the phone.

The figure was closer.

A pale face.

Dark eyes.

Smiling.

Adam dropped the phone.

The screen cracked.

From the floor, the phone continued recording.

And Adam heard his own voice whisper:

"I don't think I can do this anymore."

But he hadn't spoken.

•

End of Story 07.

08

THE VOICE FROM THE EMPTY ROOM

Grief doesn't always leave when the person does.

Every night at 10:15 p.m., someone knocked on the door.

Three knocks.

Always three.

Knock.

Knock.

Knock.

Hana had heard it for forty-two nights.

The first time, she thought it was a neighbour.

The second time, she thought it was the wind.

By the seventh night, she stopped checking.

By the twentieth, she began waiting for it.

Tonight was the forty-third.

She sat alone in the living room.

The house was warm.

The windows were closed, but the smell of rain lingered in the air.

A small fan turned slowly beside her.

The television was on, but muted.

10:14 p.m.

Hana looked at the clock.

Her hands tightened around her mug.

10:15.

Knock.

Knock.

Knock.

She closed her eyes.

"Goodnight, Abang."

Silence.

She opened her eyes.

The front door remained closed.

Nobody stood outside.

•

Her brother had died four months earlier.

A road accident.

It happened suddenly.

There had been no warning.

No goodbye.

One phone call.

One hospital.

One body beneath a white sheet.

After the funeral, everyone told Hana the same thing.

"You have to be strong."

She hated that sentence.

Strong for Mum.

Strong for the family.

Strong because people expected grief to have an ending.

But grief didn't end.

It changed shape.

Some mornings, she forgot he was gone.

She would walk into the kitchen and expect him to be there.

Sometimes she would see his slippers beside the door and forget.

Sometimes she heard his laugh from another room.

She knew it wasn't real.

At least, she thought she did.

•

The first time she heard his voice was six days after the funeral.

She was washing dishes.

The kitchen was warm.

Water ran over her hands.

Then someone called her name.

"Hana."

She froze.

The voice came from the living room.

She dried her hands.

"Abang?"

Nothing.

She walked into the living room.

Empty.

She stood there for several seconds.

Then she laughed.

It was grief.

It had to be.

She went back to the kitchen.

A minute later, she heard it again.

"Hana."

This time, she cried.

•

She told her mother.

Her mother listened.

Then said:

"Maybe he came to say goodbye."

Hana stared at her.

"Mak."

"What?"

"He's dead."

"I know."

"Then don't say things like that."

Her mother looked down.

"I just mean..."

"I know what you mean."

Her mother didn't say anything else.

But later that evening, Hana noticed her mother had placed a small glass of water outside her brother's old bedroom.

•

After that, the family began treating the house differently.

They left his room untouched.

His clothes remained in the wardrobe.

His books stayed on the shelf.

His bed was still made.

Nobody wanted to move anything.

One evening, Hana's cousin visited.

She told him about the knocking.

He looked serious.

"You hear it every night?"

"Yes."

"Same time?"

"10:15."

He looked toward the hallway.

"Maybe he's trying to tell you something."

Hana laughed.

"Or maybe the pipes are making noise."

Her cousin shook his head.

"No."

"What?"

"You know what I mean."

She did.

She didn't want to.

•

The knocking continued.

Forty-three nights.

Forty-three times.

Always three knocks.

Then one night, something changed.

After the knocking, Hana heard footsteps.

She sat on the sofa.

The hallway was dark.

Step.

Step.

Step.

Slowly approaching.

She stood.

"Abang?"

The footsteps stopped.

Her heart beat faster.

"Is that you?"

Silence.

Then a voice.

"Open the door."

Hana froze.

The voice came from her brother's bedroom.

She walked toward it.

Her hand trembled as she reached for the handle.

She opened the door.

The room was dark.

Moonlight entered through the curtains.

His bed was empty.

His chair was empty.

His photographs were exactly where they had always been.

Then she noticed something.

His desk drawer was open.

She was certain she had closed it.

She walked closer.

Inside was an envelope.

Her name was written on it.

HANA.

She picked it up.

Her hands were shaking.

She opened it.

Inside was a single piece of paper.

Three words.

Don't blame yourself.

Hana sat on the floor.

She began crying.

•

The next morning, she showed the letter to her mother.

Her mother read it.

Then looked at Hana.

"Did you write this?"

"No."

"Are you sure?"

"Yes."

Her mother touched the paper.

She began crying too.

They sat together in silence.

Neither of them said the word *ghost*.

They didn't need to.

•

That evening, Hana searched her brother's room.

She found old photographs.

Receipts.

A broken watch.

A notebook.

And finally, a second letter.

This one had no name.

She opened it.

It contained a single sentence.

If I leave before you, don't follow me.

Hana's breathing stopped.

She read it again.

Then again.

She remembered the conversation.

Three months before the accident.

They had been sitting on the balcony.

Her brother had joked:

"If I die first, don't become sad forever."

She had thrown a pillow at him.

"Shut up."

He had laughed.

She had forgotten about that conversation.

Until now.

She held the letter against her chest.

For the first time since his death, she smiled.

•

At 10:15 p.m., the knocking came.

Knock.

Knock.

Knock.

Hana stood in the hallway.

She didn't open the door.

Instead, she whispered:

"You're not outside."

Silence.

"You're here."

Nothing.

She smiled through her tears.

"But I know what you want."

The house became completely still.

Hana looked toward her brother's room.

"I'll be okay."

The lights flickered.

A cold breeze passed through the hallway.

Then she heard his voice.

Very softly.

"Promise?"

Hana closed her eyes.

"I promise."

Silence.

Then the knocking stopped.

For the first time in forty-three nights...

there were no more knocks.

•

The following morning, Hana woke early.

Sunlight filled the room.

For the first time in months, the house didn't feel heavy.

She opened her brother's bedroom window.

Fresh morning air entered.

Birds were singing outside.

She began packing his belongings.

Not throwing them away.

Just moving them.

Making space.

As she folded his clothes, she found something beneath his pillow.

A small voice recorder.

She pressed the button.

Her brother's voice filled the room.

"Testing."

Hana laughed.

The recording continued.

"I don't know if this thing works."

A pause.

Then:

"Hana, if you're listening to this..."

Hana stopped folding.

His voice became softer.

"I know you're going to blame yourself."

She closed her eyes.

"Don't."

A pause.

"You always think you should have done something."

Another pause.

"You couldn't."

Hana began crying.

The recording ended.

She sat on the bed.

For several minutes, she didn't move.

Then she smiled.

"Goodbye, Abang."

A breeze moved through the room.

The curtains lifted gently.

For a moment, she thought she saw someone standing beside the door.

A familiar figure.

Smiling.

Then the sunlight shifted.

And the room was empty.

•

That night, Hana sat in the living room.

10:14 p.m.

She looked at the clock.

10:15.

Nothing.

10:16.

Nothing.

She smiled.

She turned off the television.

The house was quiet.

For the first time, she didn't wait for the knocking.

She went upstairs.

Closed her bedroom door.

And slept.

•

At exactly 10:15 the following night, the old house remained silent.

Except for one sound.

From inside the empty bedroom.

A voice recorder clicked on by itself.

A man's voice whispered:

"Goodnight, Hana."

Then it clicked off.

•

End of Story 08.

09

THE HEALER'S LAST PATIENT

He had spent thirty years fighting things nobody could see.

Until one day, he realized the thing he was fighting wasn't there.

The rain had been falling since sunset.

By midnight, the village road had disappeared beneath a thin layer of water.

Inside the small wooden house, the air smelled of camphor, wet earth, and burning leaves.

Pak Rahman sat cross-legged on the floor.

In front of him was a small bowl of water.

Beside it lay several bottles of oil, bundles of dried leaves, and an old wooden box.

The only light came from a yellow bulb hanging from the ceiling.

A young woman sat opposite him.

Her name was Mira.

She had been crying for almost an hour.

Pak Rahman watched her carefully.

"What did you see?"

Mira wiped her face.

"Nothing."

"What did you hear?"

"Nothing."

"Then why are you afraid?"

She looked at him.

"Because I don't know what's happening to me."

Pak Rahman nodded.

He had heard those words many times.

For thirty years, people had come to his house with the same fear.

Some heard voices.

Some couldn't sleep.

Some saw shadows.

Some believed something was following them.

He had helped many of them.

At least, he believed he had.

He reached for the bowl.

"Close your eyes."

Mira obeyed.

He began reciting.

The rain became louder.

The wooden walls creaked.

The flame from the small candle beside him moved gently in the wind.

Then Mira whispered:

"Please stop."

Pak Rahman opened his eyes.

"Why?"

"I don't want this."

"What don't you want?"

"The prayer."

He frowned.

"Why?"

Mira opened her eyes.

"Because nothing is inside me."

Pak Rahman stared at her.

For some reason, that sentence stayed with him.

•

Mira returned three nights later.

Then again.

Then again.

Every time, she said the same thing.

"I'm not possessed."

Pak Rahman became frustrated.

"Then why are you here?"

She looked down.

"Because my family thinks I am."

He didn't answer.

"My mother says I'm not myself anymore."

"Are you?"

Mira hesitated.

"I don't know."

"What happened?"

She stared at the floor.

"I haven't slept properly."

"For how long?"

"Almost two months."

"Do you hear voices?"

"No."

"See things?"

"No."

"Then what?"

Mira's voice became quiet.

"I feel empty."

Pak Rahman frowned.

"What do you mean?"

"I wake up and don't want to get out of bed."

She wiped her eyes.

"I don't enjoy anything anymore."

She took a breath.

"Sometimes I sit in the shower for an hour because I don't know what else to do."

Pak Rahman didn't speak.

Mira continued.

"I told my mother."

"And?"

"She said someone had disturbed me."

Pak Rahman looked at the bowl.

He suddenly didn't know what to say.

•

His own mother had taught him the same way.

When he was young, people came to their house seeking help.

His mother would listen.

She would pray.

She would give them water.

Sometimes she would tell them something was following them.

Sometimes she was right.

At least, that was what Pak Rahman remembered.

He had never questioned it.

People believed him.

People thanked him.

People came from other villages.

Eventually, people began calling him **ustaz**, even though he never formally claimed the title.

He became known as someone who could remove things from people.

And once people believed that about him, he began believing it about himself.

•

One afternoon, Mira's mother arrived without her daughter.

Pak Rahman opened the door.

"Where is Mira?"

Her mother looked exhausted.

"She won't come."

"Why?"

"She says she doesn't want another treatment."

Pak Rahman nodded.

"She needs to."

The woman looked at him.

"She says she needs a doctor."

Pak Rahman felt something uncomfortable in his chest.

"Doctor?"

"She wants to see a psychiatrist."

He was silent.

Then the woman asked:

"Do you think she's possessed?"

Pak Rahman looked toward the road.

Rain clouds were gathering in the distance.

He had answered that question hundreds of times.

This time, he couldn't.

"I don't know."

The woman stared at him.

It was probably the first time anyone had heard those words from him.

•

That night, Pak Rahman couldn't sleep.

The rain began again.

He lay on his mattress and stared at the ceiling.

He remembered Mira sitting across from him.

I feel empty.

He had heard people describe strange things.

But never that.

He got up.

Walked into his treatment room.

Turned on the light.

The room looked different at night.

The bottles.

The bowls.

The dried herbs.

The old books.

Everything that had once made him feel certain suddenly looked like objects.

Just objects.

He opened one of his oldest books.

Inside were handwritten notes from his mother.

Names.

Dates.

Symptoms.

Treatments.

Results.

Pak Rahman turned the pages.

Then stopped.

One name caught his attention.

A woman.

Thirty years earlier.

Her symptoms were almost identical to Mira's.

No sleep.

No appetite.

Does not leave room.

Cries without reason.

Pak Rahman read the next line.

Possession suspected.

Then:

Treatment unsuccessful.

He turned the page.

Nothing.

No further notes.

He closed the book.

For the first time, he wondered what had happened to her.

•

The next morning, he went to the village cemetery.

He found the woman's name on an old grave.

He stood there for a long time.

An elderly man was sitting nearby.

Pak Rahman recognized him.

"Do you remember her?"

The old man looked at the grave.

"Yes."

"She came to my mother."

"Yes."

"What happened to her?"

The old man sighed.

"She died."

Pak Rahman's throat tightened.

"How?"

"She stopped eating."

"Why?"

"People said something was inside her."

Pak Rahman looked down.

"Was there?"

The old man stared at him.

"Who knows?"

Pak Rahman didn't answer.

The old man continued.

"Later, they took her to the hospital."

"And?"

"She had been sick for years."

Pak Rahman looked at the grave again.

"What was wrong with her?"

The old man shrugged.

"Depression, they said."

Pak Rahman closed his eyes.

The rain began falling lightly.

•

That afternoon, Pak Rahman went to Mira's house.

Her mother opened the door.

"Where is she?"

"Upstairs."

"Can I see her?"

The woman hesitated.

Then moved aside.

Mira was sitting beside the window.

She looked tired.

Pak Rahman sat across from her.

For several seconds, neither spoke.

Finally, he said:

"I was wrong."

Mira looked at him.

"What?"

"I don't know what is happening to you."

She stared at him.

"But I don't think something is inside you."

Mira's eyes filled with tears.

Pak Rahman continued.

"I think you are suffering."

She looked down.

"I don't know how to fix it."

"You don't have to."

He nodded.

"Then let's find someone who does."

•

Two weeks later, Mira saw a psychiatrist.

Then a psychologist.

Then she started treatment.

It wasn't quick.

There was no dramatic cure.

No smoke.

No screaming.

No spirit leaving her body.

Some days were better.

Some were worse.

But slowly, she began sleeping again.

She began eating.

She started leaving the house.

She laughed one afternoon.

Her mother cried when she heard it.

Pak Rahman never took credit.

When people asked what happened, he simply said:

"She needed help."

•

Months later, another family came to his house.

A teenage boy.

His mother said he had changed.

He didn't sleep.

He didn't eat.

He stayed inside his room.

"He talks to himself," she said.

Pak Rahman listened.

Then asked:

"Has he seen a doctor?"

The mother shook her head.

"Someone said he might be possessed."

Pak Rahman looked at the boy.

The boy wouldn't make eye contact.

Pak Rahman remembered Mira.

He remembered the grave.

He remembered the old book.

He remembered how easily fear could become a diagnosis.

He stood.

"Take him to the hospital first."

The mother looked confused.

"But..."

"If they tell you there is nothing medically wrong, come back."

She nodded slowly.

As they left, Pak Rahman returned to his treatment room.

He looked at the bowl of water.

For thirty years, he had believed that his job was to remove what people couldn't see.

Now he wondered whether sometimes the most important thing was simply to listen to what people could say.

He reached for his old book.

Then stopped.

He opened the drawer.

And placed the book inside.

He locked it.

Outside, the rain began again.

Three soft knocks came from his front door.

Pak Rahman froze.

Knock.

Knock.

Knock.

He slowly walked toward the door.

His hand rested on the handle.

Then a woman's voice whispered from outside.

"Pak Rahman."

He closed his eyes.

He knew that voice.

The woman from the grave.

His mother's old patient.

The woman who had died thirty years ago.

"Pak Rahman."

He opened the door.

Nobody was there.

Only rain.

He looked down.

A small, wet notebook lay on the ground.

He picked it up.

The first page was covered in handwriting.

His mother's handwriting.

But the final sentence had been written recently.

Fresh ink.

"You were right to stop."

Pak Rahman stared at the page.

Then slowly looked toward the dark road.

For the first time in thirty years, he wasn't sure whether he had just witnessed something supernatural...

or whether some truths simply refused to stay buried.

•

End of Story 09.

10

THE GIRL WHO NEVER SLEPT

*After enough nights without sleep,
even your own reflection can become a stranger.*

At first, Lina thought she was simply tired.

It had been three nights since she had slept properly.

Three nights wasn't unusual.

People worked late.

People worried.

People drank too much coffee.

People survived.

She could survive.

That was what she told herself.

On the fourth night, she stood in her kitchen at 3:17 a.m.,
staring at the kettle.

The apartment was silent.

The refrigerator hummed.

Rain tapped against the window.

Lina pressed the button.

The kettle began to boil.

She waited.

Her eyes burned.

She couldn't remember the last time she had slept for more than
two hours.

The kettle clicked.

She poured the water into a cup.

Then stopped.

There was already another cup sitting on the counter.

Filled with hot water.

She stared at it.

She didn't remember making it.

•

She lived alone.

That fact suddenly felt important.

Lina picked up the second cup.

The ceramic was warm.

She looked around the kitchen.

Nothing.

She checked her phone.

3:19 a.m.

She opened her messages.

No new notifications.

She looked at the cup again.

Maybe she had forgotten.

That happened when people were tired.

She poured it into the sink.

Then went back to bed.

•

At 4:02 a.m., she heard footsteps.

Outside her bedroom.

Slow.

One step.

Then another.

Lina opened her eyes.

The room was dark.

She held her breath.

The footsteps stopped.

She waited.

Nothing.

She checked the time.

4:03.

She closed her eyes.

A whisper came from the hallway.

"Lina."

Her eyes opened.

She sat upright.

Nobody was there.

She switched on the lamp.

The hallway was empty.

She laughed quietly.

"Okay."

She rubbed her face.

"Definitely need sleep."

•

The next morning, Lina called her doctor.

"I haven't been sleeping."

"How long?"

"Almost a week."

"How many hours per night?"

"Maybe one."

The doctor became serious.

"You need to rest."

"I know."

"Are you seeing things?"

Lina hesitated.

"No."

That was a lie.

She didn't know what she was seeing.

The doctor told her to come in.

Lina agreed.

Then forgot about the appointment.

•

That afternoon, she went to work.

The office was bright.

Too bright.

The fluorescent lights hurt her eyes.

Her colleague looked at her.

"You okay?"

"I'm fine."

"You look terrible."

"Thanks."

He laughed.

She didn't.

She stared at her computer.

The screen blurred.

For a second, she saw a message.

GO HOME.

She blinked.

The message disappeared.

Her colleague leaned over.

"What are you looking at?"

"Nothing."

He looked at the screen.

"There isn't anything."

Lina stared.

She knew.

She knew what she had seen.

But she also knew what sleep deprivation could do.

She didn't tell anyone.

•

That night, she took sleeping medication.

She checked the instructions three times.

One tablet.

She swallowed it.

Drank water.

Turned off the lights.

And waited.

11:32 p.m.

12:18 a.m.

1:04 a.m.

Nothing.

Her eyes remained open.

At 2:27 a.m., she heard the front door unlock.

Lina sat upright.

Her apartment door had just opened.

She could hear the lock turning.

Slowly.

She grabbed her phone.

No one should be entering.

The door opened.

A figure walked into the apartment.

Lina couldn't see the face.

She stayed completely still.

The figure walked toward the kitchen.

Then disappeared.

Lina waited.

She slowly got out of bed.

Walked into the hallway.

Nothing.

The front door was locked.

She checked it twice.

Then three times.

She returned to bed.

She looked at the clock.

2:28.

She whispered:

"I'm losing my mind."

From the kitchen came a reply.

"No."

Lina froze.

The voice sounded exactly like hers.

•

The following morning, she went to the doctor.

She told him everything.

The footsteps.

The voice.

The figure.

The doctor listened carefully.

"When did you last have a full night's sleep?"

"I don't remember."

"That's the problem."

He explained that severe sleep deprivation could cause hallucinations, confusion, memory problems and difficulty distinguishing dreams from reality.

Lina nodded.

"So I'm not crazy?"

"I didn't say that."

She stared at him.

He smiled gently.

"I said you're exhausted."

He recommended treatment and rest.

Lina left feeling hopeful.

Maybe there was an explanation.

Maybe nothing supernatural was happening.

Maybe she just needed sleep.

•

That evening, she went home.

She cleaned the apartment.

Closed the curtains.

Locked the door.

Turned off every light.

She took her medication.

Then lay down.

For the first time in days, she felt calm.

She closed her eyes.

Sleep came quickly.

•

She woke at 3:17 a.m.

The room was dark.

She felt rested.

For the first time in a week, her head felt clear.

She smiled.

Then noticed someone sitting at the end of her bed.

A woman.

Lina stared.

The woman was facing away from her.

Long hair.

White shirt.

Bare feet.

Lina couldn't move.

"Who are you?"

The woman didn't answer.

Lina reached for the lamp.

The woman turned.

It was Lina.

Her own face.

Her own eyes.

But the other Lina looked exhausted.

Terrified.

She whispered:

"Don't sleep."

Lina's hand froze.

"What?"

The other Lina leaned closer.

"If you sleep..."

She stopped.

Lina waited.

"...I wake up."

The room became silent.

Lina looked toward the clock.

3:17 a.m.

The same time.

Every night.

She slowly turned back toward the bed.

The other woman was gone.

•

Lina went to the bathroom.

She splashed cold water onto her face.

She looked into the mirror.

Her reflection looked normal.

She laughed.

"Okay."

She dried her face.

Then noticed something.

Her reflection was still smiling.

Lina wasn't.

She stopped.

The reflection slowly raised its hand.

Lina didn't.

The reflection touched the mirror.

Then wrote something in the fogged glass.

SLEEP.

Lina stepped backward.

The bathroom light flickered.

She closed her eyes.

When she opened them, the writing was gone.

She stared at herself.

"Enough."

•

The next morning, Lina called her doctor.

"I slept."

"Good."

"But I had another episode."

"What happened?"

She told him.

There was a long silence.

Then:

"Lina, I want you to come to the hospital."

"Why?"

"Now."

She felt uneasy.

"Is something wrong?"

"We need to talk."

•

At the hospital, the doctor showed her a photograph.

Lina stared.

It was her bedroom.

Taken from the doorway.

She recognized everything.

Her bed.

Her lamp.

Her curtains.

Her chair.

But there was someone sitting on the bed.

Lina.

She was sleeping.

The doctor looked at her.

"This photograph was taken last night."

Lina shook her head.

"I live alone."

"I know."

"Who took it?"

"We don't know."

Lina stared at the photograph.

Then noticed something.

The bedroom clock.

3:17 a.m.

She looked at the doctor.

"Where did you get this?"

"It was sent to the hospital."

"By who?"

The doctor turned the photograph over.

There was writing on the back.

Three words.

SHE IS AWAKE.

Lina's hands began shaking.

"What does that mean?"

The doctor didn't answer.

Her phone rang.

Unknown number.

She answered.

Silence.

Then her own voice whispered:

"Doctor..."

Lina looked at him.

The voice continued through the phone.

"Don't let her sleep."

The call ended.

Lina stared at the doctor.

Neither spoke.

Then, from somewhere behind them, a woman began laughing.

It sounded exactly like Lina.

•

End of Story 10.

11

THE DIAGNOSIS

Sometimes, giving your pain a name makes it easier to understand.

*Sometimes, you become so desperate for a name that you start looking for something
to be wrong with you.*

The first time Hakim searched "**Why do I feel empty?**", it was 1:13 a.m.

His room was dark.

The curtains were closed, and the air-conditioner hummed quietly above him.

Outside, rain tapped against the window.

Hakim sat on the floor beside his bed, laptop balanced on his knees.

He had been staring at the ceiling for almost an hour.

Nothing had happened.

That was the problem.

His life was fine.

He had a job.

A family.

Friends.

A small apartment.

Bills that were paid on time.

There was no tragedy.

No major loss.

No obvious reason for him to feel the way he did.

Yet something inside him felt empty.

He opened the search bar.

Why do I feel empty all the time?

He pressed Enter.

Thousands of results appeared.

He clicked the first article.

Then another.

Then another.

After twenty minutes, he searched something different.

How do I know if I have depression?

He began reading.

Loss of interest.

Fatigue.

Difficulty concentrating.

Changes in sleep.

Feeling hopeless.

Hakim stopped.

He had some of those.

Maybe...

He was depressed.

For the first time in months, he felt relieved.

•

The next morning, Hakim called in sick.

He stayed in bed until noon.

His mother called.

"Are you working today?"

"No."

"Are you sick?"

"I'm just tired."

"You sound strange."

"I'm okay, Mak."

She paused.

"Do you want me to come over?"

"No."

"Are you sure?"

"Yes."

After the call ended, Hakim opened his laptop again.

He searched:

High functioning depression.

Then:

Signs of personality disorder.

Then:

Can trauma happen without knowing it?

Every search gave him another possibility.

Every possibility made him feel a little better.

Because if there was something wrong with him...

then maybe the emptiness wasn't his fault.

•

A few weeks later, Hakim told his friend Farhan.

"I think I have depression."

Farhan looked at him.

"What makes you think that?"

Hakim explained everything he had read.

Farhan listened.

Then asked:

"Have you seen a doctor?"

"No."

"You should."

Hakim nodded.

"I will."

But he didn't.

Instead, he continued researching.

•

Soon, Hakim knew the language.

He learned words he had never used before.

Dissociation.

Triggers.

Emotional dysregulation.

Attachment issues.

Trauma response.

Personality disorder.

He watched videos of people describing their experiences.

Sometimes he would stop halfway through a video and think:

That's me.

Other times:

I do that too.

He began keeping notes on his phone.

Things he remembered.

Things he felt.

Things he thought might be symptoms.

He called it:

My mental health journal.

At first, it was an attempt to understand himself.

Then it became something else.

A search.

For a diagnosis.

•

Eventually, Hakim saw a psychologist.

Her name was Aina.

Her office was small and quiet.

Warm yellow lighting.

A bookshelf.

Two chairs facing each other.

A small plant near the window.

Hakim sat down.

Aina opened her notebook.

"Why did you decide to come?"

Hakim answered immediately.

"I think I have a personality disorder."

Aina looked at him.

"Why?"

"I've done a lot of research."

"How much?"

"A lot."

She smiled slightly.

"That's not quite an answer."

Hakim looked away.

"I've taken online tests."

"And what did they say?"

"That I might have one."

"Might?"

"Yes."

Aina nodded.

"Have you ever received a professional diagnosis?"

"No."

"Have you ever taken medication?"

"No."

She wrote something down.

Then asked:

"When did you first start feeling like something was wrong?"

Hakim thought.

"About six months ago."

"What happened six months ago?"

"Nothing."

"Nothing?"

"Nothing major."

Aina looked at him.

"How was your life at that time?"

Hakim shrugged.

"Normal."

She nodded.

"And now?"

"Normal."

"Yet you feel something is wrong?"

"Yes."

"Why?"

Hakim didn't know.

•

Over the next few sessions, Aina asked him about his life.

His work.

His family.

His relationships.

His sleep.

His friendships.

His expectations.

His future.

Eventually, she said:

"I don't think you have the disorder you're worried about."

Hakim stared at her.

"Then what's wrong with me?"

Aina closed her notebook.

"That's an interesting question."

"Why?"

"Because you're assuming there must be something wrong with you."

Hakim frowned.

"But I don't feel normal."

"What does normal mean?"

He didn't answer.

She continued.

"You seem lonely."

Hakim looked down.

"You seem disconnected from your life."

Silence.

"You seem unhappy with where you are."

Hakim's eyes became wet.

"But none of those things mean you have a personality disorder."

He wiped his eyes.

"Then why do I feel like this?"

"That," Aina said gently, "is something we can work on."

•

Hakim stopped going after the fifth session.

He told Farhan that Aina didn't understand him.

"She thinks I'm just lonely."

"Maybe you're lonely."

"That's not it."

"Then what is?"

Hakim became quiet.

He didn't know.

But he knew one thing.

He wanted a diagnosis.

Not a possibility.

Not a discussion.

A name.

Something official.

Something he could point to and say:

This is why I am like this.

•

He found a private consultant online.

The website looked professional.

There were photographs of doctors.

Testimonials.

Certificates.

A long list of mental-health conditions.

Hakim booked an online consultation.

The man introduced himself as Dr. Razak.

He asked Hakim a series of questions.

Do you feel abandoned?

Sometimes.

Do your emotions change quickly?

Sometimes.

Do you struggle with relationships?

Sometimes.

Do you feel empty?

Yes.

Do you fear being alone?

Sometimes.

Hakim answered honestly.

But the questions were broad enough that almost anything could fit.

At the end of the session, the man said:

"I believe you have a personality disorder."

Hakim went completely still.

"What?"

"You show several significant traits."

Hakim's heart began beating faster.

"Are you sure?"

"Yes."

Finally.

Someone had said it.

Something was wrong.

And now he knew what.

•

The diagnosis arrived by email two days later.

Hakim printed it.

He read it again.

Then again.

He placed the document beside his bed.

For several minutes, he simply stared at it.

He felt something he hadn't felt in months.

Relief.

He finally had an explanation.

•

He told his family.

His mother cried.

His younger sister became worried.

His friends started treating him differently.

When Hakim became angry, they asked:

"Is this because of your condition?"

When he didn't answer messages:

"Are you having an episode?"

When he cancelled plans:

"Do you need space?"

At first, Hakim liked it.

People were paying attention.

People were careful with him.

People listened.

The diagnosis had become part of his identity.

•

His girlfriend, Sara, noticed the change.

One evening, they sat in her car outside her apartment.

Rain covered the windshield.

The engine was off.

Neither spoke.

Finally, Sara said:

"You're different."

Hakim looked at her.

"What do you mean?"

"Everything has become about your diagnosis."

He frowned.

"It's part of who I am."

"Maybe."

She looked at him.

"But it doesn't explain everything."

Hakim became defensive.

"You don't understand."

"Then help me understand."

He said nothing.

Sara sighed.

"You keep using it whenever something happens."

"What do you mean?"

"When you're angry, it's your disorder."

Silence.

"When you hurt me, it's your disorder."

Hakim looked away.

"When you refuse to talk to me, it's your disorder."

"That's not fair."

"I'm not saying you're faking."

Her voice became softer.

"I'm saying you can't use a diagnosis to avoid responsibility."

Hakim stared at her.

She opened the car door.

"I'm tired."

Then she left.

•

Three days later, Sara moved out.

She didn't block him.

She didn't insult him.

She simply stopped answering.

Hakim called.

Nothing.

He sent messages.

Nothing.

Finally, her sister replied.

She needs space.

Then another message.

Please stop contacting her.

Hakim stared at the screen.

His chest tightened.

He looked at the diagnosis on his desk.

He whispered:

"This is because of my disorder."

But the words sounded different now.

Almost empty.

•

That night, Hakim opened the document again.

He looked at the clinic's name.

Something bothered him.

He searched it.

Nothing.

He searched the doctor's name.

Nothing.

He checked the registration number.

Invalid.

Hakim's stomach dropped.

He looked through his emails.

The consultation had been conducted through a private website.

There was no hospital.

No clinic address.

No verified medical registration.

He stared at the diagnosis.

His hands began shaking.

The man had not been a psychiatrist.

The diagnosis was worthless.

Hakim had paid someone online to tell him he was mentally ill.

And he had believed him.

•

The next morning, Hakim returned to Aina.

She looked surprised.

"I made a mistake."

She gestured toward the chair.

"Tell me."

Hakim placed the document on the table.

She read it.

Then looked at him.

"This isn't a legitimate diagnosis."

"I know."

"How did you get it?"

He explained.

Aina listened quietly.

When he finished, she asked:

"How do you feel?"

Hakim laughed.

"Stupid."

"Anything else?"

"Angry."

"At him?"

"At myself."

She waited.

Hakim stared at the floor.

"I thought..."

He stopped.

"What?"

"I thought if someone could tell me what was wrong with me..."

His voice cracked.

"...then I'd finally understand myself."

Aina nodded.

"That makes sense."

Hakim looked at her.

"You don't think I'm crazy?"

"No."

"Then what am I?"

She smiled gently.

"You're Hakim."

He laughed through his tears.

"That's not a diagnosis."

"No."

She leaned back.

"It's a person."

•

Months passed.

Hakim stopped searching for symptoms.

He stopped taking online tests.

He stopped trying to match himself to strangers on the internet.

He continued therapy.

Not because he had finally discovered what disorder he had.

But because he realized he didn't need one to justify getting help.

He learned that loneliness could hurt.

That burnout could feel like emptiness.

That uncertainty could feel like failure.

That a person could be unhappy without being mentally ill.

And that mental illness itself wasn't something shameful.

But neither was ordinary human suffering.

•

One night, almost a year after his first search, Hakim sat at the same desk.

The room was dark.

The rain tapped against the window.

He opened his laptop.

The search bar was empty.

His fingers hovered over the keyboard.

For a moment, he almost typed:

What disorder do I have?

He stopped.

Deleted the thought.

Then typed something else.

How do I feel better?

He stared at the question.

For once, he didn't need an immediate answer.

He closed the laptop.

The room became quiet.

No ghost appeared.

No voice whispered from the darkness.

There was only Hakim.

Sitting alone.

Still figuring himself out.

And for the first time, he understood something:

You don't need a diagnosis to prove that your pain is real.

And you don't need to be broken to deserve help.

•

End of Story 11.

12

THE LAST DOOR

They spent their lives asking whether the things they saw were real.

They never asked why they needed them to be.

The house had been empty for eleven years.

Nobody in the village went near it after sunset.

During the day, it looked ordinary.

Old.

Forgotten.

The paint had peeled from the walls, the garden had become overgrown, and one of the windows upstairs was permanently broken.

But at night, people said the house changed.

Lights appeared behind the curtains.

Someone walked along the hallway.

A woman stood at the upstairs window.

Sometimes, people heard knocking.

Three knocks.

Always three.

The stories had been passed from one person to another for so long that nobody remembered where they began.

Until Farid moved into the village.

He was a university student studying psychology.

He didn't believe in ghosts.

At least, that's what he told people.

•

The first time Farid saw the house, it was raining.

He was walking home after midnight.

The road was almost completely empty.

Streetlights reflected against the wet asphalt.

The air smelled of rain and soil.

As he passed the abandoned house, he heard something.

Knock.

He stopped.

Knock.

He looked toward the house.

Knock.

Three times.

Farid stared at the front door.

It was locked.

He laughed quietly.

"Probably the wind."

Then he noticed something.

There was a light upstairs.

A warm yellow light.

Farid looked up.

A woman stood behind the window.

She was staring directly at him.

Farid froze.

The woman raised her hand.

And pointed toward the house.

Then the light disappeared.

•

The next morning, Farid asked his landlord about it.

The old man became quiet.

"You saw someone?"

"Upstairs."

The landlord shook his head.

"Nobody lives there."

"I know."

"You shouldn't go there."

Farid smiled.

"Why?"

The old man looked at him.

"Because everyone who goes inside comes back different."

Farid laughed.

"That's not exactly evidence."

The landlord didn't laugh.

"Sometimes that's all you need."

•

Farid began researching the house.

Old newspaper articles.

Village records.

Stories from neighbours.

Eventually, he found something.

Twenty years ago, a woman had lived there with her daughter.

The mother had suffered from severe depression.

Her daughter had been sixteen.

One night, the girl disappeared.

Nobody knew where she went.

The mother was found dead several days later.

The official report said suicide.

But the village created another explanation.

They said the daughter had been possessed.

They said the mother had tried to remove the spirit.

They said the spirit remained in the house.

Farid read the article twice.

Then he found another story.

A young man had entered the house ten years later.

He claimed he saw a woman in the hallway.

Three days later, he disappeared.

Then another person.

Then another.

The stories became increasingly supernatural.

Farid closed the laptop.

There was something strange about all of it.

But it wasn't necessarily a ghost.

It was a pattern.

•

That night, Farid returned to the house.

He brought a flashlight.

A notebook.

His phone.

And a small camera.

The front gate creaked when he pushed it open.

The grass was wet against his shoes.

The house smelled of mould.

He opened the front door.

It wasn't locked.

Inside, the air was colder.

Dust covered the furniture.

Old photographs hung on the walls.

Farid walked slowly through the hallway.

His footsteps echoed.

Then—

Knock.

He stopped.

Knock.

The sound came from upstairs.

Knock.

Farid swallowed.

He climbed the stairs.

The hallway upstairs was dark.

At the end was a closed door.

Farid approached.

The handle was cold.

He opened it.

Inside was a bedroom.

An old bed.

A wardrobe.

A broken mirror.

And dozens of photographs taped to the wall.

Farid moved closer.

They were photographs of people.

Different people.

Different years.

But all of them had one thing in common.

They were standing outside the house.

Looking toward the same upstairs window.

Farid's breathing became slower.

He recognized some of the faces from the newspaper articles.

The missing man.

The woman who had entered the house years later.

Others.

All of them.

Then he noticed the newest photograph.

It was him.

Standing outside the house.

Taken the night before.

Farid stepped backward.

His phone rang.

Unknown number.

He answered.

Nobody spoke.

Then a woman's voice whispered:

"Why did you come?"

Farid looked around.

"Who is this?"

The voice came again.

"Why did you come?"

He whispered:

"Who are you?"

Silence.

Then:

"Ask yourself."

The call ended.

•

Farid returned to the room.

There was something written on the wall behind the photographs.

He wiped away the dust.

Words appeared.

THEY CAME LOOKING FOR HER.

Below it:

THEY FOUND THEMSELVES.

Farid stared.

Then the door behind him slammed shut.

He turned.

The room was empty.

The light from his flashlight flickered.

A woman's voice came from behind him.

"You want to know if I'm real."

Farid slowly turned.

A woman stood in the corner.

Her face was pale.

Her hair covered part of her face.

Farid couldn't move.

She looked at him.

"Do you believe in ghosts?"

He swallowed.

"No."

The woman smiled.

"Good."

She disappeared.

Farid stood alone.

The room was silent.

Then he noticed something on the floor.

A notebook.

He picked it up.

The first page contained a name.

SURI.

The woman's name.

Farid turned the pages.

It wasn't a diary.

It was a collection of notes.

Descriptions of people.

Their fears.

Their habits.

Their conversations.

Their behaviour.

Someone had been studying them.

Farid's heart began beating faster.

At the back of the notebook was a sentence:

People don't see what is there.

They see what they are afraid is there.

•

Farid understood.

The house wasn't haunted.

At least...

not in the way everyone believed.

Someone had created the story.

Someone had learned what frightened people.

Someone had used the house.

But who?

He looked at the photographs again.

Then he saw something he hadn't noticed before.

Every photograph had been taken from inside the house.

Someone had been watching.

The entire village had been observed.

The stories.

The rumours.

The disappearances.

Maybe the house wasn't calling people.

Maybe people were being brought there.

Farid stepped toward the door.

Then heard footsteps downstairs.

Someone else was inside.

He turned off his flashlight.

The footsteps climbed the stairs.

Slowly.

One step.

Another.

Another.

Farid hid behind the wardrobe.

The bedroom door opened.

A man entered.

Farid recognized him.

His landlord.

The old man walked toward the wall.

He removed a photograph.

Behind it was a small opening.

He took something out.

A camera.

Farid's stomach dropped.

The landlord turned.

He was looking directly at the wardrobe.

"You shouldn't have come here."

Farid stepped out.

"How long?"

The old man stared at him.

"What?"

"How long have you been doing this?"

The old man smiled sadly.

"You think I'm the ghost?"

Farid said nothing.

The old man sat on the bed.

"I was her brother."

Farid froze.

"Suri?"

He nodded.

"My sister was sick."

The old man's voice became quieter.

"People called her possessed."

He looked around the room.

"They prayed over her."

"They took her to healers."

"They locked her inside."

"They told her that something evil was inside her."

He looked at Farid.

"And eventually..."

He stopped.

"...she believed them."

Farid didn't speak.

The old man continued.

"She died here."

"And the girl?"

"My niece."

"The daughter?"

The old man looked toward the broken window.

"She ran away."

Farid stared.

"So the ghost story..."

"I created some of it."

"Why?"

The old man looked at the photographs.

"Because nobody listened when she was alive."

His voice cracked.

"But they listened to a ghost."

•

Farid lowered his notebook.

"So the people who disappeared?"

"Most came here looking for ghosts."

"And?"

"I never hurt them."

The old man looked toward the hallway.

"But some saw things."

"How?"

"Fear."

He tapped his temple.

"People see what they expect to see."

Farid thought about the woman at the window.

The voice.

The photographs.

The stories.

"What did I see?"

The old man looked at him.

"What did you need to see?"

•

Farid left the house before sunrise.

He never told the village what he had discovered.

Not immediately.

Instead, he spent months documenting the history of the family.

The mother's illness.

The daughter's disappearance.

The village's reaction.

The healers.

The rumours.

The people who had been labelled.

The people who had been ignored.

Eventually, he wrote everything down.

Not as a ghost story.

As a story about what happens when people don't understand suffering.

•

Years later, Farid returned to the village.

The house was gone.

Only an empty piece of land remained.

A small wooden sign stood beside it.

There was no explanation.

Just one sentence:

**SOME THINGS BECOME MONSTERS BECAUSE WE
REFUSE TO CALL THEM BY THEIR REAL NAMES.**

Farid stood there for a long time.

Then he heard something behind him.

Knock.

He turned.

Nobody.

Knock.

The road was empty.

Knock.

Three times.

Farid smiled.

He knew better than to immediately call it a ghost.

He walked away.

Behind him, the empty land remained silent.

But in the window of the house across the road...

a woman was watching.

She smiled.

Then disappeared.

•

END OF STORY 12

And perhaps that was the truth about all the stories.

Some ghosts were real.

Some were memories.

Some were fear.

Some were grief.

Some were lies told by people who needed an explanation.

And some...

were simply people who had been suffering,

waiting for someone to listen.

•

End of Collection.

AFTER THE LAST STORY

Not every shadow is a ghost.

Not every voice comes from another world.

Sometimes, the darkness comes from somewhere inside us.

⋮

We spend so much time asking:

"Is it real?"

Maybe the better question is:

"What happened to this person?"

Because behind every strange story...

there is a person.

Behind every person...

there is a story.

And sometimes, the thing that looks like a ghost

is simply someone asking

to be understood.

⋮

— THE END —

Some stories are meant to frighten you.

Some are meant to make you wonder.

These stories were written to make you look twice.